India & Chad:

Partnering for Opportunities, Building a Brighter Tomorrow

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Foreword

Chad occupies a distinctive, if underexplored, position within Central Africa's economic landscape. As one of the region's largest countries by land area, home to roughly 18–19 million people, a very young and fast-growing population, and a hydrocarbon endowment that has anchored the economy since 2003, the country holds long-term promise across oil and energy services, mining, agriculture, cotton and gum arabic value-addition, and pharmaceuticals. At the same time, a narrow industrial base, heavy dependence on oil revenue for fiscal resources, a challenging investment climate and persistent infrastructure constraints temper the pace at which this potential translates into realised opportunity, shaping a landscape where genuine promise and genuine caution sit closely together.

India and Chad share a relationship formalised in the years following Chad's independence and carried forward through India's Techno-Economic Approach for Africa-India Movement (TEAM-9), an active programme of ITEC, ICCR and defence training slots, and Foreign Office Consultations, most recently held in N'Djamena in February 2025. Trade between the two countries has historically been modest and episodic a large spike in 2018-19 driven by crude oil imports, followed by a sharp COVID-era decline and a gradual recovery since 2022-23 with pharmaceuticals as India's leading export and cotton and gum arabic as Chad's leading exports to India. The underlying complementarities nonetheless remain intact: India's pharmaceutical, agri-processing, textile-machinery and energy-engineering strengths align closely with gaps that Chad's own industry and government have openly acknowledged, offering a durable foundation for deeper engagement even as near-term trade volumes stay modest relative to that potential.

Looking ahead, this paper outlines a practical set of initiatives through which CCI India can support Indian businesses in engaging with Chad in a manner appropriate to current conditions whether through sector-specific market intelligence, structured business matchmaking, or institutional dialogue with Chad's relevant ministries and national chamber of commerce that can be scaled as specific opportunities mature. This Knowledge Paper examines, in a structured and evidence-based manner, the current state of Chad's economy, its priority sectors, and the opportunities and constraints shaping India–Chad economic engagement, serving as a reference for CCI India's engagement with the Embassy of India in N'Djamena, Chadian stakeholders, and Indian companies assessing the market.



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CHAD

> Explore vast deserts and cultural diversity, where landscapes and traditions shape life.



Basic Facts & Economic Overview

Chad is a landlocked nation in north-central Africa, with N'Djamena as its capital and largest city. As of 2025 projections, Chad's population is estimated at approximately 18–19 million. The official languages are French and Arabic, and the country uses the Central African CFA Franc (XAF).

Chad is classified as a low-income country with an economy heavily dependent on oil production and subsistence agriculture. Despite possessing significant natural resources, including oil and minerals, the country faces persistent challenges such as poverty, weak infrastructure, and political instability.

Economy — GDP, Structure & Recent Performance

As of 2025, Chad's nominal GDP was approximately USD 21.5 billion.

- Sectoral Composition: Agriculture (~40%); Services (~32%); Oil & Mining (~14% of GDP)
- Economic performance: Real GDP growth reached ~5.6% in 2025, but remains vulnerable to oil-price volatility, climate shocks and insecurity. Oil accounted for ~52% of fiscal revenues and ~65% of exports in 2024. Recent reforms focus on fiscal stability, economic diversification and strengthening agriculture, while infrastructure and environmental constraints continue to hinder growth.

Bilateral Trade with India: Modest but Expanding Potential

India–Chad bilateral trade remains relatively small, amounting to approximately USD 83.5 million in FY2023–24, with Indian exports accounting for USD 79.8 million and imports from Chad for USD 3.6 million.

Trade has historically fluctuated due to crude-oil imports, reaching over USD 500 million in 2018–19. India has also provided development assistance and EXIM Bank Lines of Credit supporting sectors including agriculture, agro-processing and infrastructure, creating opportunities for deeper commercial and development cooperation.

Cultural and Heritage:
Chad has a diverse cultural heritage shaped by over 200 ethnic groups. Traditional music, dance, and oral storytelling are central to its identity, while crafts like pottery, weaving, and leatherwork reflect local traditions. Both Islamic and indigenous cultural influences play a significant role in daily life.

Strategic Importance and Key Observation:

Chad holds strategic importance due to its location connecting North and Central Africa and its oil resources, which are key to its economy. It also shares borders with several countries, making it geopolitically significant in the Sahel region.
Key Observation: While oil provides major revenue, the economy remains vulnerable due to dependence on a single resource, along with security challenges and limited infrastructure.

Import and Export from India

Chad's Imports from India

- Key Import Products: Pharmaceuticals, textiles, machinery, rice, vehicles, and engineering goods
- Key Players in Import: Government procurement agencies, private traders, healthcare institutions, and distributors



Chad's Exports to India

- Key Export Products: Crude oil (limited volumes), cotton, and agricultural commodities
- Key Players in Export: Oil companies, agricultural cooperatives, and commodity exporters

Cultural and Strategic Economic Ties

India and Chad maintain cordial diplomatic relations built on shared development goals and long-standing goodwill. Cooperation spans education, technical training, and development assistance, with Chad actively joining India's capacity-building programs under ITEC. Over the years, India has supported projects in infrastructure, healthcare, and skill development, helping strengthen mutual trust. Chad's rich natural resources and central position in Africa offer scope for deeper political, economic, and technological engagement in the future.

Conclusion – Summary & Recommendation

Chad is a resource-driven economy with moderate trade engagement with India, and both countries have room to deepen cooperation in meaningful ways. Strengthening this partnership can grow through wider investment beyond oil, especially by supporting agriculture, infrastructure, and local industries that create stable growth. Building stronger training programs and knowledge-sharing platforms can also help Chad enhance skills and institutional capacity. With a focus on sustainability, long-term planning, and broader economic opportunities, both nations can build a partnership that supports steady progress and shared development.

1. COUNTRY PROFILE

A business-oriented profile of the Republic of Chad for Indian industry, investors and institutional stakeholders. Chad is a landlocked Central African country strategically positioned between North, West, Central and East Africa, bordered by Libya, Sudan, the Central African Republic, Cameroon, Nigeria and Niger. Its oil endowment, agricultural and livestock base, and gum arabic resources give the country a distinctive economic profile within the region.

For Indian industry, Chad represents a small but strategically relevant market, with opportunities extending beyond domestic demand into regional trade, energy-linked infrastructure and resource-linked sectors. The country's hydrocarbon base, agricultural and livestock resources, cotton and gum arabic value chains, and a young, rapidly growing population provide a foundation for longer-term commercial engagement. Its membership of CEMAC and location astride Sahelian and Central African trade routes also give it relevance as India seeks to broaden economic engagement with the wider African continent.

At the same time, businesses need to account for Chad's landlocked geography, a narrow and oil-dependent economy, a challenging investment climate, and significant infrastructure and connectivity constraints. Opportunities are therefore likely to be strongest in sectors where Indian companies can leverage cost competitiveness, technology and long-term partnerships, particularly in pharmaceuticals and healthcare, agriculture and food processing, cotton and gum arabic value-addition, hydrocarbons and energy-engineering services, mining, education and selected areas of digital and financial services.

Table: Chad Country Snapshot

Parameter	Detail
Official name	Republic of Chad
Capital	N'Djamena
Population	≈18.03 million (2024, INSEED / Trading Economics); estimates for 2025-26 range from ≈19.3 million (countryeconomy.com) to ≈21.7 million (geofactbook/UN-derived projections) figures vary materially by source and should be reconfirmed at time of use
Land area	≈1.284 million sq. km (landlocked; one of the larger countries in Central Africa)

Parameter	Detail
Currency	Central African CFA Franc (XAF), pegged to the Euro, shared under CEMAC
Official languages	French and Arabic (official); over 120 local languages spoken
Political structure	Presidential republic; President Mahamat Idriss Déby Itno; constitution amended October 2025 extending the presidential term from five to seven years, with no term limit
Major cities	N'Djamena, Moundou, Sarh, Abéché, Kelo
Neighbouring countries	Libya (N), Sudan (E), Central African Republic (S), Cameroon (SW), Nigeria (SW, short border), Niger (W)
Key regional memberships	African Union (AU), CEMAC (Central African Economic and Monetary Community), ECCAS, AfCFTA, WTO

1.1 Geography

Chad is entirely landlocked and spans desert, Sahelian and savanna zones, bordered by Libya, Sudan, the Central African Republic, Cameroon, Nigeria and Niger. This geography has direct and largely unavoidable commercial consequences that CCI India should communicate candidly to Indian businesses considering the market: no direct land or sea access to India, and no operational overland trade corridor between the two countries. Nearly all realistic freight movement today runs via longer sea-plus-land or air routings principally via the port of Douala in Cameroon and onward road transport into N'Djamena, or via UAE/Gulf air-freight consolidation which raises landed cost and transit time for Indian exporters relative to competitors such as China, France and Turkey, all of whom feature among Chad's leading trading partners.

High internal logistics cost. Chad's road network is limited and seasonally affected by flooding, and rail infrastructure is largely absent, which raises the cost of moving goods within the country and affects distribution economics for any Indian company considering local assembly, warehousing or distribution partnerships.

Strategic hydrocarbon and resource position. Chad's oil fields around Doba are connected to the Atlantic coast via the 1,070 km Chad–Cameroon pipeline (operational since 2003, led by ExxonMobil and partners), and the country hosts its own refinery at Djermaya, a joint venture with the China National Petroleum Corporation. This hydrocarbon backbone rather than trade volumes is Chad's principal point of leverage in regional and global commerce.

This position gives Chad strategic importance for energy-related investment, infrastructure services and resource-linked industries. For Indian businesses, opportunities may therefore

be stronger in supporting oil and gas operations, engineering, logistics, equipment supply and related industrial services than in conventional consumer-market trade.

1.2 Demographics

Chad's population is exceptionally young: more than 65% of the populace is under the age of 25, and the country has one of the highest fertility rates in the world. This youthful profile has direct relevance for Indian engagement in three areas: (i) education and skill-development services, where India's higher-education and vocational-training capacity is a natural fit for a young, growing Chadian workforce; (ii) healthcare and pharmaceuticals, where a young and growing population combined with high maternal mortality and limited domestic manufacturing sustains long-term demand for affordable generic medicines and basic healthcare infrastructure; and (iii) agriculture and livestock livelihoods, which employ roughly 80% of the population and shape rural consumption patterns far more than urban formal wages do.

1.3 Political and Administrative Structure

Chad is a presidential republic under President Mahamat Idriss Déby Itno, who assumed leadership following a 2021 transitional period and was elected in 2024. In October 2025, Chad's National Assembly and Senate approved constitutional amendments extending the presidential term from five to seven years with no term limit; the session was boycotted by some opposition parties. CCI India notes this development for institutional context only, consistent with this report's business focus, and does not take a position on it; economic policy, investment approvals and major hydrocarbon or mining concessions remain closely coordinated through central government ministries and state-linked enterprises, meaning credible engagement especially on larger investment or EPC-linked opportunities benefits materially from government-to-government (B2G) channels alongside B2B contacts.

1.4 Natural Resources

Chad's most significant resource endowments, in commercial order of relevance to India, are hydrocarbons, cotton and gum arabic, livestock, and gold. The country holds proven oil reserves of approximately 1.5 billion barrels and produced roughly 126,490 barrels per day in 2025, exported principally via the Chad–Cameroon pipeline; the oil sector contributes around 15% of GDP, 41% of government revenue and 76% of exports. Chad is also the world's second-largest producer of premium-grade gum arabic, and cotton remains a leading agricultural export, supported by a newly commissioned ginning plant (18,200 tonnes/season capacity, early 2025). Gold, largely from artisanal mining, accounts for roughly 10% of exports.

These resource endowments create opportunities for Indian companies across energy, agro-processing, commodities, mining services, and industrial inputs. Hydrocarbons offer potential